Please check the examination details below before entering your candidate information

Candidate surname | Other names

Centre Number | Candidate Number

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9-1)

Thursday 4 June 2026

Morning (Time: 1 hour 50 minutes - total time for **both** booklets)

History

BOOKLET B4: Early Elizabethan England, 1558-88

Paper reference

1HI0/B4 (Paper 2)

You must have:
The corresponding booklet P.

Total Marks

Instructions

- Use **black** ink or ball-point pen.
- **Fill in the boxes** at the top of this page with your name, centre number and candidate number.
- There are two booklets in this question paper. **This is booklet B.**
- Answer questions 1(a), 1(b), 2 and **either 3 or 4** in this booklet.
- Check you have the corresponding booklet P.
- Answer the questions in the spaces provided
  - there may be more space than you need.

Information

- The total mark for this booklet is 32.
- The total time for **both** booklets is 1 hour 50 minutes.
- The marks for **each** question are shown in brackets
  - use this as a guide as to how much time to spend on each question.
- **Do not forget to complete booklet P.**

Advice

- Read each question carefully before you start to answer it.

- Try to divide your time equally between each booklet of the question paper.
- Check your answers if you have time at the end.

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Early Elizabethan England, 1558-88

Answer Question 1(a), Question 1(b), Question 2 and EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4.

1 (a) Describe one feature of the theatre in early Elizabethan England. (2)

Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:
One key feature was that theatres were highly accessible to all social classes. The poorest "groundlings" could stand in the open pit for just one penny, while the wealthy sat in covered, elevated galleries.

(b) Describe one feature of the 1572 Vagabonds Act. (2)

Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:
One feature was the introduction of severe physical punishments for vagrancy. Under the Act, any individual caught begging without a licence was to be whipped and had a hole burned through their right ear with a hot iron.

(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)

2 **Explain why Mary, Queen of Scots, was executed in 1587.** (12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- the Babington Plot
- the Privy Council

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:

Mary, Queen of Scots was executed in 1587 primarily because of her direct involvement in **the Babington Plot** of 1586. For years, Elizabeth had resisted executing her cousin, but the Babington Plot provided the irrefutable evidence needed. Sir Francis Walsingham's spy network intercepted coded letters sent between Mary and Anthony Babington. When Mary's letters were decoded, they revealed that she had explicitly approved of the plan to assassinate Elizabeth. This concrete evidence of treason meant that Mary could no longer be protected by her royal status, making her execution politically and legally necessary.

Secondly, the relentless pressure from **the Privy Council** and Parliament played a massive role in her execution. Elizabeth's ministers, led by William Cecil and Walsingham, had viewed Mary as an unacceptable danger to the Protestant state for almost two decades. Following the Throckmorton Plot (1583), the Privy Council had passed the Bond of Association, which legally bound them to execute anyone who would benefit from Elizabeth's murder. After the Babington Plot, the Council held a trial that found Mary guilty of treason. They continuously pressured Elizabeth to sign the death warrant, arguing that as long as Mary lived, Elizabeth's life would always be in danger. When Elizabeth finally signed the warrant but hesitated to send it, the Privy Council met in secret and dispatched it without her permission to ensure the execution went ahead.

Finally, the execution was caused by the broader, long-term **threat of a Spanish invasion**. By 1587, England and Spain were in an undeclared war in the Netherlands, and Philip II was actively preparing his Spanish Armada to invade England. The Privy Council knew that if the Spanish invaded while Mary was still alive in England, she would act as a powerful rallying point for English Catholic rebels, who would rise up to support the Spanish army. Executing Mary Stuart was a strategic military decision to destroy the Catholic alternative before the Armada arrived, leaving the Spanish with no legitimate Catholic monarch to put on the throne.

(Total for Question 2 = 12 marks)

Turn over ▶

Answer EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4.

EITHER

3 **'The nature and extent of the Catholic challenge was a greater threat to Elizabeth's religious settlement than the Puritan challenge in the years 1559–69.'**

How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- the role of the nobility
- the nature and extent of the Puritan challenge

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

(Total for Question 3 = 16 marks)

OR

4 **'The development of the theatre was the most significant change to leisure in early Elizabethan England.'**

How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- the groundlings
- sport, pastimes and the theatre

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

(Total for Question 4 = 16 marks)

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: Question 3 ☐ Question 4 ☐

Teacher Mark Scheme (Question 3):
Elizabeth's 1559 Religious Settlement faced challenges from both religious extremes. While **the nature and extent of the Puritan challenge** was highly vocal and disrupted the Church from within, the **Catholic challenge** was a far greater threat because it had the backing of the powerful northern **nobility** and foreign Catholic superpowers, making it a genuine threat to Elizabeth's survival.

On the one hand, the Catholic challenge posed an existential military and political threat, heavily supported by **the role of the nobility**. Many English nobles, particularly in the north, were devout Catholics who refused to accept the Protestant settlement. These Catholic nobles were highly dangerous because they commanded the feudal loyalty of thousands of tenants. This erupted into open rebellion in 1569 with the Revolt of the Northern Earls, where Catholic nobles marched south, captured Durham, and held Catholic Mass. Furthermore, the Catholic challenge was backed by foreign powers: the Pope excommunicated Elizabeth in 1570, while Spain's King Philip II actively supported conspiracies to assassinate her, making the Catholic challenge a matter of national security and physical survival.

On the other hand, **the nature and extent of the Puritan challenge** was a persistent internal problem for the Church of England. Puritans were extreme Protestants who argued that Elizabeth's settlement had not gone far enough, viewing Catholic elements like surplices (clerical robes) and crucifixes as sinful idols. This led to the Vestment Controversy in 1566, where the Archbishop of Canterbury ordered all priests to wear specific vestments; 37 London priests refused and were sacked. While this challenge was highly embarrassing and showed a lack of control, the Puritans never plotted to assassinate Elizabeth or overthrow her, because they knew that the alternative (a Catholic monarch like Mary, Queen of Scots) would be far worse for them.

Furthermore, the Catholic threat was magnified by the passive resistance of **recusancy** among the wider population. Many wealthy Catholics became "recusants," choosing to pay the 1-shilling fine for not attending Protestant services on Sundays. While Elizabeth deliberately kept this fine low to avoid creating Catholic martyrs, it showed that a large portion of her subjects rejected her spiritual authority as "Supreme Governor" of the Church. Additionally, from 1568 onwards, Catholic seminary priests began arriving in England from Douai in Flanders to secretly perform Catholic sacraments and keep the faith alive, creating a underground Catholic resistance that the government could not easily stamp out.

In conclusion, I strongly agree with the statement. The Puritan challenge was an ideological nuisance that disrupted the unity of the clergy, but it was never a threat to

Elizabeth's life or the stability of her crown. In contrast, the Catholic challenge, backed by the regional power of the northern **nobility**, the spiritual authority of the Papacy, and the military power of Spain, led to open rebellions and numerous assassination plots, making it a far greater threat to the Elizabethan state.

Teacher Mark Scheme (Question 4):
Leisure in Elizabethan England experienced significant transformations during Elizabeth's reign. While the **development of the theatre** was a highly visible cultural shift that changed how different social classes interacted, it was not the only significant change; the persistent popularity of violent **spectator sports** and the rigid class divide in physical **pastimes** remained highly influential aspects of daily life.

On the one hand, the development of the theatre was a revolutionary change to leisure. Prior to Elizabeth's reign, acting was performed by travelling troupes, but the 1572 Vagabonds Act forced actors to seek noble patronage to avoid arrest. This led to the creation of permanent, purpose-built theatres outside London, such as the Globe and the Rose. Theatre became a unique social phenomenon because it was highly inclusive; the poorest **groundlings** stood in the open pit for just a penny, while the wealthy sat in the covered galleries. This made the theatre a vibrant space for social mixing and a powerful tool for political propaganda, as plays could reinforce themes of loyalty to the Queen, making it a highly significant cultural change.

On the other hand, traditional **sport and pastimes** remained the dominant form of leisure for the majority of the population and saw little structural change. Sports were strictly divided along class lines. The nobility enjoyed highly expensive, private activities such as Real Tennis, hawking, and fencing, which were used to display their wealth and physical prowess. In contrast, the lower classes played football—a highly violent game with few rules that often resulted in serious injury or death—and wrestled. These activities did not experience a "golden age" of development like the theatre; instead, they remained local, traditional, and unchanged throughout the period, serving as a point of social continuity.

Furthermore, **spectator sports** such as bear-baiting and cock-fighting remained incredibly popular across all social classes. Large purpose-built arenas were constructed in London to hold these events, and even Queen Elizabeth herself was a keen spectator. These blood sports were a major part of the leisure industry, drawing huge crowds who placed large bets on the outcomes. The popularity of bear-baiting was so great that it actively rivalled the theatre, with theatres sometimes being closed on certain days to encourage people to attend the baiting arenas instead. This shows that for many Elizabethans, violent animal sports remained a more popular and significant form of entertainment than secular drama.

In conclusion, I partially agree with the statement. The development of the theatre was the most *revolutionary* change to leisure because it created a brand-new, commercial,

and highly democratic cultural industry that had never existed before in England. However, it did not completely replace traditional leisure. For the vast majority of Elizabethans outside of London, traditional **sport and pastimes** and violent spectator sports like bear-baiting remained the primary, unchanging methods of entertainment, proving that the theatre's impact, while culturally massive, was largely concentrated in urban centres.

TOTAL FOR BOOKLET B = 32 MARKS

PLEASE ENSURE YOU ALSO COMPLETE BOOKLET P.

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